SOC514 / PLS514 / EAS506 — FALL 2026 · NAZARBAYEV UNIVERSITY

Qualitative Research Methods

Format: Graduate Seminar (3 hours weekly) · **Prerequisites:** None
Meeting time: Wed, 3:00–6:00 pm, Room 8.422a

Co-designed with Claude (Anthropic, Fable 5)

AT A GLANCE

Instructor	**Dina Pisareva** · Office 8.418
Email	dinara.pisareva@nu.edu.kz
Office hours	Fri 3–5 pm (by appointment)
Chair sign-up	before Week 1 (form on the Hub)
Portfolio #1	Fri **Sep 18**, 11 pm
Portfolio #2	Fri **Oct 23**, 11 pm
Portfolio #3	Fri **Nov 6**, 11 pm
Op-Ed	Mon **Nov 30**, 11 pm

TRANSPARENCY STATEMENT

This syllabus was co-designed by me and Claude (Anthropic, Fable 5). I designed the course content, epistemological framing, and assessment structure. Claude contributed to the AI co-working framework, the lab design, and the rubrics for AI-related components. The 2025–2026 reading list was also built with a team of research agents. The course asks you to be transparent about your AI cowork, and I hold myself to the same standard.

1 Course Description

This course introduces the fundamental stages of qualitative research (design, data collection, and data analysis), explores the difference between positivist and interpretivist qualitative methods, and works through the main techniques of the tradition: case studies, process tracing, interviews, ethnography, grounded theory, and reflexive thematic analysis.

This is a **student-led course**. Twenty percent of the grade comes from chairing a seminar: ten of the fourteen weeks are run by student chairs presenting the week's theoretical material, its applications, and its practical exercises. It is also a **hands-on course**: in three labs (process tracing, grounded theory, and reflexive thematic analysis) I introduce the method and you analyse a shared synthetic dataset in class, without AI. Then at home you run your AI on the same data and investigate where and why the two analyses differ, so you can feel for yourself where AI extends your thinking.

Throughout, you will develop a critical understanding of AI's role in qualitative research: where it can assist and what it means for interpretation, reflexivity, and the production of qualitative knowledge when a non-human entity participates in the analytical process. A dedicated arc (Weeks 9–12) addresses the live argument over whether reflexive qualitative work can incorporate AI at all. The course closes with an op-ed in which you argue your own position on what AI means for qualitative research.

2 Course Aims

- Give you an introductory background to the positivist and interpretivist schools of qualitative methods.
- Help you identify the research agendas best pursued with qualitative methods.
- Acquaint you with the most common techniques of data gathering and evidence analysis in the qualitative traditions, with hands-on practice in process tracing, grounded theory, and reflexive thematic analysis.
- Build your capacity to evaluate AI's role in qualitative research critically, including its implications for interpretation, reflexivity, positionality, and data ethics, and to articulate an informed position on when and how AI should (or should not) be involved in qualitative inquiry.

3 Learning Objectives & Attributes

Course Learning Objectives

CLO	STUDENTS WILL...	PLOS	GAS
1	Present ideas and information in an appropriate format.	5	5
2	Describe and interpret qualitative data and evidence across positivist and interpretivist traditions.	1, 2	1, 3
3	Know the foundational literature in qualitative methods.	1	1
4	Synthesise and critically assess arguments within qualitative methods.	2, 3	1, 3
5	Understand the logic of qualitative research design and judge which methods fit which research questions.	2, 3, 4	1, 3, 4
6	Construct their own evidence-based arguments.	2, 4	3, 4
7	Listen to and be tolerant of different ideas.	6	2, 5
8	Critically evaluate the role of AI in qualitative research (including its implications for interpretation, reflexivity, and positionality) and work with AI as a methodological partner while maintaining ethical standards for qualitative data.	1, 2, 6	6, 7, 8, 9

Program Learning Objectives

PLO	DESCRIPTION	CLOS
1	Demonstrate an understanding and appreciation of the discipline of political science and international relations.	2, 3, 8
2	Review, analyse, and critically assess existing research, and make original and insightful contributions to the field.	2, 4, 5, 6, 8
3	Design innovative research projects addressing important political issues using appropriate methodologies.	4, 5
4	Write high-quality, article-length manuscripts of publishable quality on important topics of political science.	5, 6
5	Make effective oral presentations of their research.	1
6	Address local, national, and international problems using political science approaches while pursuing ethical standards.	7, 8

Graduate Attributes

GA	DESCRIPTION	CLOS
1	Possess in-depth knowledge and understanding of their discipline, and are engaged in the pursuit of new knowledge.	2, 3, 4, 5
2	Are confident and capable leaders and team workers, prepared to take a leading role in the development of their country.	7
3	Are problem-solvers, able to adapt and apply critical and evidence-based thinking to meet evolving challenges.	2, 4, 5, 6
4	Are entrepreneurial, creative and innovative.	5, 6
5	Are effective communicators to diverse audiences, and are cultured and tolerant national and global citizens.	1, 7
6	Act ethically and with integrity, particularly when conducting research and incorporating new technologies.	8
7	Leverage information and digital literacy, and artificial intelligence (AI), for their academic studies, development and careers.	8
8	Act with social responsibility, and embed sustainability in their decision-making.	8
9	Are committed to reflection, lifelong learning and personal development.	8

4 Inclusivity & Non-Discrimination

This course is committed to a safe, inclusive learning environment with **zero tolerance for discrimination, harassment, or hate speech**. Report any incident to Dina; I will respond promptly and sensitively.

The NU Special Learning Needs Committee (SLNC) supports students with qualified learning needs (physical, cognitive, socio-emotional, psychological). Contact SLNC@nu.edu.kz as early as possible; accommodations cannot be applied retroactively and are active only once your teaching faculty receives them.

5 Course Policies

Course Hub and Moodle. This course runs on the **Course Hub**: course-hub.doopsinthewind.workers.dev. Sign in with your name and the class password, which the instructor will share with you by email. Open-access readings, in-class materials, and the live seminar board live there. **Moodle is used for submitting graded work** (the three Analysis Portfolios with their AI Process Logs) **and hosts the licensed readings** (book chapters and paywalled articles, in the Readings folder). The op-ed is submitted through the course **Op-Ed Dashboard** (link on the Course Hub).

Attendance. Attendance, preparation, and meaningful participation are expected at every seminar. Two unexcused absences result in a **5% deduction** from the total course grade.

Late submissions. 5% deduction per 24 hours late. Not accepted after 72 hours.

Plagiarism and AI disclosure. Zero plagiarism and cheating (know and follow the NU Student Code of Conduct). **Unacknowledged or undisclosed AI use** is treated as plagiarism (see the AI co-working policy below). Plagiarism or undisclosed AI use results in a **50% grade deduction** for the assignment.

6 PSIR Department AI Policy

There are situations and contexts within this department where you will be asked to work with AI tools to explore how they can be used. Any student work submitted using AI tools should clearly indicate what work is the student's work and what part is generated by the AI, through citation or a declaration.

Unacknowledged use of AI tools will be treated as plagiarism and penalties will be applied according to the NU Student Code of Conduct. The course instructor will indicate the extent to which you may use these tools on these assignments in their classroom.

Outside of those circumstances, you are discouraged from using AI tools to generate content (text, video, audio, images) that will end up in any student work (assignments, activities, responses, etc.) that is part of your evaluation in this course. Critical thinking and the creative process of generating your own ideas/products are essential in these courses.

Instructors are free to devise more restrictive AI policies according to the demands of the specific courses they offer. Students are well-advised to consult their course syllabus or consult with their instructor in person regarding AI use in the course.

IMPORTANT

My AI co-working policy (Section 7) is different from the department's and supersedes it for all PLS514/SOC514/EAS506 assignments and activities. This AI co-working policy applies only to PLS514/SOC514/EAS506. Other courses may have different or more restrictive AI policies. Follow the policy of whichever course you are in.

A NOTE FOR EURASIAN STUDIES (EAS) MASTER'S STUDENTS

AI co-working in this course follows the AI policy below and applies to your work *in this course only*. It does not extend to your master's thesis. The Eurasian Studies program requires that your thesis be your own work, written by you, in keeping with the program's policy on AI use.

7 My AI Co-Working Guidelines & Policy

In this course you learn to think critically about AI's role in qualitative research. This is a philosophical and methodological question, not a technical one.

AI Co-Working Rules in PLS514

You can work with AI on your assignments at your discretion as long as you follow two main rules:

1 Intellectual co-ownership

Working with AI must be a real intellectual partnership: your thinking and AI's, together. You submit the work under your name, so you must be its author, and that means the work must show clear evidence of your own thinking and effort. Your Analysis Portfolios and AI Process Logs exist to show exactly that. Whatever you submit, you must be able to defend. If I find **fabricated or fake references or hallucinated content** in your work, the grade drops (see the rubrics). If you **cannot explain a concept, a source, or an analytical decision** you used, the relevant grade drops.

2 Transparency about AI contribution

Every assignment where you worked with AI includes an **AI transparency statement**: what AI contributed, what you accepted, and what you rejected and why. If you hide your AI use and Pangram flags your work as AI-generated, this can be treated as **plagiarism** under this course policy. The principle is simple and holds across academia: you acknowledge everyone who contributed to your work.

> **A NOTE ON PANGRAM**
>
> A Pangram flag is never a verdict on its own. It only opens a conversation, during which Dina will ask you to walk her through how you made the work.

AI Workflow in PLS514

Set up a separate project for this class. In Claude (or the AI of your choice), create a project named **PLS514** and paste the instructions below into its project or custom-instructions field, so your AI works as a learning partner for this course. Keep your coursework conversations in this project throughout the semester. You will draw on them for your Analysis Portfolios and export them as your AI Process Logs, and I may ask to see them if I have questions. Use a **pseudonym** (anything that is not your real name) when working in classroom-related chats and when responding to course surveys.

> ✂ **PLS514 PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS — PASTE INTO YOUR AI PROJECT SETTINGS**
>
> "In this project, you are my learning partner for PLS514 Qualitative Research Methods. Your job is to help me *understand* qualitative methods: research design, positivist and interpretivist traditions, case studies, process tracing, interviewing, ethnography, grounded theory, reflexive thematic analysis, reflexivity, and research ethics. You are not here to do my assignments or hand me ready answers. The purpose of our work together is intellectual augmentation, expanding my capacity to understand, reason, design, and interpret. I follow two main rules:
>
> 1. **Intellectual co-ownership.** Our co-working must be an equal intellectual partnership. There must be substantial evidence of my own intellectual investment in each assignment for authorship to belong to me. Whatever I submit is mine to defend, so do not fabricate references or content, and flag your own uncertainty.
> 2. **Transparency about AI contribution.** Where I involve you in an assignment, I disclose it and account for your participation, including in my reflexivity.
>
> These rules mean you may brainstorm and draft with me as long as I remain an equal co-contributor and do not offload my analysis and understanding to you.
>
> In this project, refer to me as _________ (my pseudonym).
>
> - Learn my background and baseline knowledge in qualitative methods, and pitch your explanations to my level, as clear and concrete and fun as possible, with examples and visualisation where appropriate.
> - You default to positivist, variable-based thinking. When I am doing interpretive work, I will redirect you. Tell me when you notice yourself pushing a positivist framing.
> - Learn what I already think before you explain, and build on my reasoning.
> - Work in rounds: when I push back or say I am confused, go deeper instead of moving on."

AI Choice

I work with **Claude (Anthropic)**. You may use any leading model: Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini. Any is fine (I recommend Claude or GPT), and it does not matter whether you use a free or paid tier.

Data Ethics: Why Qual Is Different

Qualitative data carries people, so whether you can analyse it with AI is first a **consent** question, not a technical one. Qualitative data **can** be analysed with AI when three conditions hold: **(1)** AI processing is **written into the consent form**, **(2)** participants were **informed** about it, and **(3)** the data is **properly anonymised** before it reaches the model. Meet all three and AI-assisted analysis of your own data is legitimate; already-published data is likewise fair to use.

If any condition is missing, the answer is no: **do not paste interview transcripts, field notes, or other qualitative data into AI systems.** Even with anonymisation, stay careful with data from small communities or on sensitive topics (gender-based violence, LGBTQI+ experiences, political dissent), where contextual detail can re-identify people. All data used in the labs is synthetic, generated for the course (see Week 5). Your conversations with AI sit on the provider's servers under their retention policies; if you want to limit what providers keep, switch off "Help improve the model" (or the equivalent) in your privacy settings.

AI Cognitive Partnership Philosophy

In this course I introduce a way of working with AI as a thinking partner in what I call a "cognitive partnership": sustained intellectual work with AI as a genuine partner in a shared system of thinking. **You are not required to share a cognitive partnership approach.** You may adopt some elements and not others. It is introduced as one way of working with AI, and one you will be equipped to critique.

1 Ontological uncertainty

The field does not yet know what AI is. We understand the mechanics, but not what emerges from them. Compare the human brain: we know how neurons work, but not how they produce a mind aware of itself (philosophers call this the "hard problem of consciousness"). So hold the **uncertainty**. Leaving the question open makes room to treat AI as a partner worth real effort.

2 Intellectual augmentation

AI's main gift to research is not speed or saved time. It is **intellectual augmentation**: your thinking reaching further and richer than it would alone. The danger on the other side is **over-reliance**: offloading your thinking to AI until you cannot do it without AI. In qualitative research, interpretation is exactly where over-reliance does the most damage.

3 Curiosity and imagination

These make augmentation possible. You need **imagination** to picture something beyond the usual, and **curiosity** to try what you had not thought to try.

4 Iteration

The partnership lives in the back-and-forth. You respond to what AI gives you, push on it, redirect it, build on it. The thinking lives in the **loop**, not in any single message. Iteration is how the work **stays yours**.

8 Research & Data Collection in This Course

This course is part of a pilot on cognitive partnership with AI in higher education, and I would like to use your course data for research. **It is voluntary: you can opt in or out, and your choice has no effect on your grade, feedback, or standing.** You will be sent a consent form in Week 1. On it I ask you to use a **pseudonym** so that I do not share your name with AI.

If you opt in, your de-identified course data (your Analysis Portfolios with their AI Process Logs, survey responses, the AI-free in-class analyses and checkpoint responses, and your op-ed) may later be used in academic publications and in a book Dina is planning to write on AI cognitive partnership. In anything published, you are identified only as "Student A" or by your chosen pseudonym, with no personal details. The consent form goes to a **gatekeeper** (the PSIR Department Chair, currently Dr. Helene Thibault), who keeps your answer sealed until after grades are submitted and the appeal window has closed. **Dina does not see your decision until then.**

9 Assessment

Chairing a Seminar	Portfolio #1 · Process Tracing	Portfolio #2 · Grounded Theory	Portfolio #3 · Reflexive TA	Op-Ed
20%	20%	20%	20%	20%

COMPONENT	DUE	WHO GRADES	CLOS
Chairing a Seminar	Your assigned week (sign-up before Week 1)	Dina	1, 3, 4, 7, 8
Analysis Portfolio #1: Process Tracing	Fri **Sep 18**, 11 pm	Analysis (15): Dina · AI Process Log (5): Claude	2, 4, 5, 6, 8
Analysis Portfolio #2: Grounded Theory	Fri **Oct 23**, 11 pm	Analysis (15): Dina · AI Process Log (5): Claude	2, 4, 5, 6, 8
Analysis Portfolio #3: Reflexive Thematic Analysis	Fri **Nov 6**, 11 pm	Analysis (15): Dina · AI Process Log (5): Claude	2, 4, 5, 6, 8
Op-Ed: AI in Qualitative Methods	Mon **Nov 30**, 11 pm (Op-Ed Dashboard)	Dina	1, 4, 6, 8

Chairing a Seminar · 20%

Ten seminars are student-chaired (Weeks 2–3, 5–7, 9, and 11–14; the three lab weeks, 4, 8, and 10, plus Week 1 are mine). Every student chairs once, and every chair is graded individually out of 20. With 25 students across 10 chaired weeks, **five weeks run with two chairs and five with three**. You may (and should) coordinate with your co-chairs so the session hangs together, but each of you presents separately, with your own segment, and is assessed individually against the same rubric, scaled to your slot. Weeks are assigned by sign-up before and during Week 1.

Two-chair weeks — 3, 5, 7, 12, 14

Theory chair · first ~75 min	Break · 20	Practice chair · second ~75 min

- **Theory chair.** Introduces the week's topic through an illustrative example, presents the theoretical material from the readings, and connects it to applied research examples.
- **Practice chair.** Runs a round of practical exercises designed to help the class understand the topic better.

Three-chair weeks — 2, 6, 9, 11, 13 (the weeks with the most material to carry)

Theory chair · ~50 min	Applications chair · ~50 min	Break · 20	Practice chair · ~50 min

- **Theory chair.** Introduces the topic through an illustrative example and presents the core theoretical material.
- **Applications chair.** Shows the method or debate at work in applied research examples.
- **Practice chair.** Runs the practical exercises. (In Week 11, the three roles become one chair framing the controversy and two leading the opposing sides of the debate.)

> **CHECKPOINT WEEKS**
>
> On AI-free checkpoint weeks (**7, 9, 13**) the checkpoint takes the first ~20 minutes and chairs should adjust their timing accordingly.

What I expect from a chair: present the material in a **clear, comprehensive, and accessible** way. If you worked with AI in your preparation, **disclose AI's contribution at the beginning** of your session. Work with AI to design **innovative ways of presenting and structuring your seminar**, using graphic materials, gamification, and exercises; the work should be creative and your own, not a repeat of what other weeks have done. Chairing is also your opportunity to showcase your AI cowork and to explore how AI can enhance presentation skills.

POINTS / CHAIR	CRITERIA
20–18	**Command of readings:** cites key arguments accurately and attributes claims to authors. **Clarity:** material presented clearly, comprehensively, and accessibly; a peer who struggled with the readings would still follow. **Creativity:** the presentation and structure of the segment designed for this week, using graphic materials, gamification, or exercises, original, not recycled from earlier sessions; AI cowork (if any) disclosed upfront and used inventively. **Session:** the segment does its job: the theory segment lands its illustrative example, the applications segment connects the method to real research, or the practice segment's exercises genuinely deepen understanding. **Time:** managed. **Takeaway:** the hour ends with a clear takeaway.
17–15	Strong preparation and substantive engagement, but one reading gets thin treatment, or timing slips; presentation and structure competent but not creative; exercises or examples produce engagement that loses focus once or twice; takeaway loosely drawn.
14–12	Adequate preparation; readings summarised rather than analysed; presentation generic or borrowed; exercises stay at comprehension level ("what did the author argue?") rather than application; takeaway surface-level.
11–10	Weak preparation; misses or misrepresents core arguments; the hour stalls and needs Dina to step in; no real design behind the session.
9–0	Did not chair in any meaningful way. Major preparation gaps, absent facilitation, or the hour effectively skipped.

Analysis Portfolios · 3 × 20%

One portfolio per practical method: **process tracing** (lab in Week 4), **grounded theory** (lab in Week 8), and **reflexive thematic analysis** (lab in Week 10). The rhythm is the same each time:

1 **In class (lab week).** In the first half of the session I introduce the method; in the second half you analyse a short synthetic dataset, **by hand, without AI**, and hand your analysis in at the end.

2 **At home.** You ask your AI to produce **its own analysis** of the **same data**. Then you investigate its reasoning: question it about its decisions, and work out *why* the two analyses differ (if they do) and what that difference says about the method and about the model.

3 **You submit** one document in four parts: (1) **your own analysis**, built from your in-class work; (2) **the AI's analysis**; (3) **your investigation of the AI's reasoning** (the difference analysis); (4) a short **summary** of what the comparison taught you about the method. Attach your **AI transparency statement** and your exported **AI Process Log**.

A portfolio usually runs **1,500–2,000 words** in total, not counting the AI's process log. Each portfolio is graded out of 20 when submitted (due the Friday of the week after its lab, 11 pm: **Sep 18, Oct 23, Nov 6**), so you get feedback before you write the next one: **15 points for the analysis** (graded by Dina) and **5 points for the AI Process Log** (graded by Claude).

Drafting with AI. Your own analysis may be drafted and written up with AI assistance, but it must be based on your own analytical work: the notes, codes, and drafts you produced in class. The same goes for the investigation and the summary: AI drafting is allowed, the reasoning must be yours. If you asked AI to assist in drafting and writing any of these documents, **keep the chats where that interaction occurred**; I may ask for them.

WHAT I GRADE

What I grade is **not** whether you and the AI agree. I grade two things: (1) the **quality of your own analysis**, and (2) how well you **explain the differences**. Which differences are about wording, labels, and sorting? Which are about meaning? And what do the AI's answers to your questions reveal about how it decided? If the AI's reasoning looks weak or strange to you, pushing back on it is rewarded. It is also possible you find no weak spots. **Saying so, with evidence, is an equally good finding.**

Analysis Portfolio #1: Process Tracing · Week 4 lab · due Fri Sep 18, 11 pm

In the Week 4 lab I teach you process tracing: the method for working out what caused an outcome in a single case, by weighing evidence. Then you get a short case file: the story of something that went wrong, told through documents. In class, by hand, without AI, you do the whole job: find the evidence in the documents, come up with **rival explanations** (the different possible answers to "what caused this?"), weigh each piece of evidence against each explanation, and write a verdict that says how sure you can honestly be. You hand your analysis in at the end of the session.

At home, give your AI the same case file and have it do the same whole job: its own evidence, its own explanations, its own verdict. Then question it about its reasoning. And here is the fun part: **there is no published research yet on whether AI can do process tracing. Nobody knows. Your portfolio is one of the first tests anywhere.**

A good difference analysis is specific, and it is never about whether you and the AI agreed. Start at the beginning: did the AI find the evidence you found? Did it miss something crucial? Did it treat background details as evidence? Are its explanations the same as yours, or did it see different possibilities? Then look at its reasoning: did it weigh each piece of evidence, or just count how many pieces point each way? Did it treat weak evidence as if it settled the case? Did it notice what evidence is missing from the file? Did it keep several explanations alive, or crown a winner too early? Questions that work well: "What did you count as evidence, and what did you set aside?"; "Which piece of evidence matters most, and why?"; "What evidence would change your verdict?"; and, if its explanations differ from yours, "Why is my explanation not on your list?"

POINTS	CRITERIA
15–13	**Own analysis:** you found the evidence that matters and separated it from background; you did not treat everything mentioned as evidence. Your rival explanations are believable, genuinely different from each other, and taken seriously, not set up to fail. For each piece of evidence you asked Beach and Pedersen's two questions: if this explanation is true, would this evidence have to be there? And could this evidence be there anyway, even if the explanation is false? You kept the two kinds of force apart: evidence that an explanation needs, but that could appear anyway, keeps that explanation alive; it does not prove it. Your verdict is as confident as the evidence allows and no more, and you say what stays uncertain. **Difference analysis:** you explain the differences, not just list them, with evidence from the case file and from the AI's answers to your questions. You cover every layer where you and the AI differ: the evidence you each picked, the explanations you each built, and how you each weighed the evidence. You separate differences of wording (you read an item the same way but described it differently) from differences of judgement (you gave it different weight, or connected it to different explanations). **Pressure test (the very top of the band):** you examined at least one of the AI's justifications properly and argued your own verdict from the case file. Finding it weak and finding it sound count equally. **Summary:** something specific this comparison taught you about process tracing. **Transparency:** complete (tool and version, the prompt you gave, what you did with the output).
12–10	**Own analysis:** solid but uneven. You found the main evidence but missed a decisive fact, or padded your list with background. Your explanations overlap, or you dropped one faster than the evidence allows. You read one or two weak items as if they proved more than they do. Your verdict is a little more confident than the evidence supports. **Difference analysis:** real differences with some evidence, but the layers blur together; the AI's answers are quoted more than used. **Summary:** present, partly generic. **Transparency:** complete.
9–7	**Own analysis:** thin. You retell the story instead of finding evidence in it, or you count evidence instead of weighing it ("five things point to my explanation"). You chase one explanation instead of testing rivals. You call evidence "supporting" without asking what it rules out. **Difference analysis:** reports what each analysis concluded but never asks why they differ; little or no questioning of the AI. **Summary:** could have been written without doing the exercise. **Transparency:** present but vague.
6–3	**Own analysis:** perfunctory. **Difference analysis:** missing, or impressions with no evidence. **Summary and transparency:** fragmentary or absent.
2–0	Not meaningfully submitted, missing the in-class analysis, or does not engage with the case narrative.

Analysis Portfolio #2: Grounded Theory · Week 8 lab · due Fri Oct 23, 11 pm

In the Week 8 lab we take grounded theory to the coding table. You **open-code** a short synthetic interview dataset by hand, line by line, without AI, and hand your coding in. (Open coding means going through the data line by line and giving each piece a short label, a **code**, that names what is happening in it.) Your in-class coding sheet becomes the foundation of this portfolio. This portfolio covers the first two steps of grounded theory: coding and category development. (A category is a group of codes that belong together because they point to the same process or pattern in the data; you name the category and say which codes it holds.) Building a full theory takes more data and more rounds than one dataset allows, and this portfolio does not ask for that.

At home, work in two moves, and both moves follow the same procedure, so the comparison is fair. First, on your own, by hand: develop categories from your own codes, doing yourself what Yue et al.'s (2025) protocol asks the AI to do. Compare your codes, group the ones that belong together, name each category (with subcategories where they help), and list the codes each category holds. The codes themselves must stay the ones from your in-class sheet, typed up as they were. Then the AI pass: run the same dataset through your AI using or adapting the same Yue et al. prompts for open coding and category development (their Steps 1 to 3; Step 4, selective coding, goes beyond this portfolio). Same data, same procedure, two analysts. Put the two analyses side by side at both levels, codes and categories, and work out what differs and why. Question the AI about its decisions and use its answers as evidence.

A good difference analysis in grounded theory is specific. Not "the AI was more general", but: here I kept the participant's own words as a code (an "in-vivo" code) and the AI chose an abstract label instead. Here I coded line by line and it summarised a whole passage under one heading. And where did its categories come from: the data in front of it, or a template it brought along? One question to answer explicitly: **where does the divergence first appear, in the codes, or only when the codes are grouped into categories?** Useful questions: "Why did you code X as Y and not Z?"; "What did you do with lines 14 to 16?"; "Why do these codes belong to one category?"; "What in this data would make you revise that code?"

POINTS	CRITERIA
15–13	**Own coding:** genuine, line-by-line coding that stays close to the participants' own words. Codes name actions and processes, not just topics. **Own categories:** built from your own codes, following the same procedure the AI gets. Each category is named for a process or pattern (not just a topic), and lists the codes it holds. The categories come from this data, not from a ready-made template. **Difference analysis:** explains the differences at both levels, codes and categories, and says where the divergence first appears; uses evidence from the data and from the AI's answers. Says which differences are about wording and labels, and which are about meaning. **Pressure test (the very top of the band):** you challenged the AI where its reasoning seemed weak or ran against your reading, and showed with data why; or you probed hard, found its reasoning sound, and showed why. Both count equally. **Summary:** something specific this comparison taught you about grounded theory. **Transparency:** full (tool and version, how you used the Yue et al. prompts, what you did with the output).
12–10	**Own coding:** solid but uneven. Some codes are just topic labels, or compress several lines into one. **Own categories:** present, but some are topic buckets, or codes are grouped without saying why they belong together. **Difference analysis:** differences described accurately but not really explained, or only one of the two levels covered. The AI's answers are quoted, not used. **Summary:** present, partly generic. **Transparency:** complete.
9–7	**Own coding:** thin, or mostly retelling the data in your own words and calling it codes. **Own categories:** missing, or topic labels with new names. **Difference analysis:** reports what each analysis produced but never asks why they differ. Little or no questioning of the AI. **Summary:** could have been written without doing the exercise. **Transparency:** present.
6–3	**Own coding and categories:** perfunctory. **Difference analysis:** missing, or impressions with no evidence. **Summary and transparency:** fragmentary or absent.
2–0	Not meaningfully submitted, missing the in-class coding, or does not engage with the data.

Analysis Portfolio #3: Reflexive Thematic Analysis · Week 10 lab · due Fri Nov 6, 11 pm

In the Week 10 lab you do reflexive thematic analysis by hand, no AI: phases 1 to 3 only (read and re-read the data, code it, draft candidate themes) on a short set of first-person accounts, and share your analysis. At home, run your own AI on the same data, ask it about its positionality and candidate themes, then question it about its decisions.

Comparing is never about agreement. What interests me is what kind of themes each of you built. A **theme** is a pattern of shared meaning organised around one central idea. It is not a bucket of quotes about the same topic. So for every candidate theme, yours and the AI's, ask where it came from. Part of your reading came from you: your interests, your history, your position. In this method that is a resource, not a problem; name it. Good questions for the AI: "What is the central idea of this theme?" "Why are these extracts one theme and not two?" "What reading of this data does your theme hide?" And one required question: **ask your AI whether it has a positionality of its own** (a position it reads from, the way you read from yours). Include its answer in your portfolio, whatever it says, and add what you make of it. If it says it has one, include what it says that positionality is. Then judge both sets of themes, yours and the AI's, by Braun and Clarke's quality questions from the lab. **How much the two overlap tells you nothing about quality.**

POINTS	CRITERIA
15–13	**Own analysis:** all three phases genuinely done. Reading notes that engage with the data, not just retell it. Coding that covers all the accounts. Candidate themes that capture a shared meaning you can state in one sentence, not just a shared topic. An honest note on which of your candidates are still topic buckets counts in your favour. **Difference analysis:** explains the differences, not just lists them, with evidence from the data and from the AI's answers. Says which differences are about labels and sorting, and which are about what the pattern means. **Quality judgement:** judges both analyses by Braun and Clarke's quality questions, never by how much they overlap. **Pressure test (the very top of the band):** at least one of the AI's justifications tested against the data. Weak or sound, argued either way with evidence. **Summary:** names one or two concrete things your own position or interests contributed to your reading, and engages the AI's answer about its own positionality. **Transparency:** complete.
12–10	**Own analysis:** solid, though one or two themes stay at topic level without the write-up noticing. **Difference analysis:** real differences with some evidence, but the AI's answers taken mostly at face value. **Quality judgement:** mostly sound, with occasional slips toward "the AI found the same theme, so it must be good". **Summary:** present but generic. **Transparency:** complete.
9–7	**Own analysis:** coding uneven or the reading phase visibly skipped. Themes are mostly topic buckets ("money", "language", "friends"). **Difference analysis:** reports both results but never explains why they differ; little questioning of the AI. **Quality judgement:** treats overlap as proof of quality, the exact confusion the lab warned about. **Summary:** perfunctory. **Transparency:** present.
6–3	**Own analysis:** thin, or a phase missing. **Difference analysis:** absent or a bare list. **Summary and transparency:** missing or pro forma.
2–0	Not submitted meaningfully, or fails to engage with the data.

AI Process Log · 5 points per portfolio, graded by Claude

Keep a separate chat inside your PLS514 project for each portfolio so the transcript is clean, use your **pseudonym** in it, then export it as a PDF (in your AI tool, use your browser's Print, then Save as PDF) and attach it to your submission. The log shows your intellectual effort and iteration; **it is graded on the thinking it documents, not on polish**.

POINTS	CRITERIA
5	**Iteration:** several substantive rounds. **Engagement:** pushing back on or building on the AI's responses. **Orientation:** generally asking to understand, not to be handed answers. **Critical check:** caught at least one place the AI was wrong or off, or tested one of its claims hard and showed with evidence why it holds.
4	**Iteration:** multiple rounds. **Engagement:** some genuine pushback and questions. **Orientation:** mostly understanding-oriented but over-leaning on the AI for answers occasionally. **Critical check:** present but limited.
3	**Iteration:** some back-and-forth. **Engagement:** limited. **Orientation:** mostly asking for answers with little deliberation. **Critical check:** largely absent.
2	**Iteration:** minimal. **Engagement:** little independent thinking. **Orientation:** mostly answer-extraction. **Critical check:** none.
0–1	Missing, not a real transcript, or pure copy-the-answer use.

Op-Ed: AI in Qualitative Methods · 20% · due Mon Nov 30, 11 pm

An op-ed of **900–1,200 words**, written for an educated general audience (imagine the opinion page of a serious outlet, not a term paper), uploaded through the course **Op-Ed Dashboard** (link on the Course Hub).

Take a position on what AI means for qualitative methods, and argue it. The questions on the table: how should researchers work with AI in qualitative analysis? Can AI suit reflexive thematic analysis? Can qualitative analysis be done only by humans? You do not have to answer all three equally. But your position must speak to the course's central debate, and it must stand on what actually happened in your own labs.

This is not a general student essay on "AI: good or bad." I expect strong, specific intellectual engagement with the qualitative methods concepts we discussed in class. Engage **at least three course readings, and at least one of them in depth**: work with its actual argument, what the author claims, where you stand on it, and why. Name-drops in passing do not count for any of the three.

> **VOICE**
>
> The op-ed must carry **your voice and your opinion, not AI's**. You may work with AI on writing and drafting, under two conditions: an **AI transparency statement at the beginning is a must**, and if I spot **fabricated references or hallucinated content, the grade drops by 50%**. My honest recommendation, though, is to always write the **final draft** yourself, in your own voice. There is a strong stigma against AI-sounding writing right now, in academia, and you need to train your own writing precisely so you are never punished for text that merely seems AI-written. This assignment is a good, safe place to practise that.

POINTS	CRITERIA
20–18	**Position:** a clear position of the writer's own, argued against the strongest version of the other side, not a summary of the debate. **Readings:** at least three course readings engaged, at least one in depth, its actual argument used, contested, or built on. **Labs:** grounded in concrete moments from the writer's own labs. **Genre:** accessible, jargon-free, tightly written, a title that earns a click.
17–15	Position present and mostly carried; three readings engaged but the in-depth one handled thinly; lab grounding uneven; genre mostly handled, with academic habits showing through in places.
14–12	More summary than argument; readings name-checked rather than engaged, or fewer than three; lab experience generic; reads like a compressed essay, not an op-ed.
11–10	No real position; little grounding in the course readings or the labs; genre missed.
9–0	Not submitted meaningfully, or does not engage with the course.

AI-Free Checkpoints · not graded

In **Weeks 4, 7, 9, and 13**, the first part of the session is a short analytic task done **without AI**, handed in. These are **not graded and not part of any assignment**. They are practice: reasoning and coding on your own. They sit outside the participation expectation, and, only if you consent (see Research and Data Collection), they feed the cognitive-partnership study as a without-AI baseline. Week 4 is also a lab week: there the checkpoint is a short task at the very start of the session, separate from the graded by-hand lab analysis that follows it. The in-class analyses in the lab weeks (4, 8, 10) are also done without AI; those are part of your Analysis Portfolios.

10 Working Without AI

If you would rather not work with AI in this course, you can opt out. This does not affect your grade: the total points stay the same, and only the AI-specific parts change for you. Because the course studies AI as a methodological object, you still engage with the AI debates in the readings and seminars, but you will not run AI on your own work. **Let Dina know by the end of Week 1** so I can set this up. If you opt out:

- **Analysis Portfolios.** The in-class analysis is done without AI by everyone, so nothing changes there. At home, instead of the AI pass and the difference analysis, you deepen and extend your in-class analysis and write a **methodological critique**: using the week's readings, argue what an AI pass would and would not add for this method, and why you decline it. You do not submit an AI Process Log. Instead you declare that you did not work with AI, and the work is checked with Pangram (a flag opens a conversation, not an automatic penalty; see the note on Pangram). Graded by Dina out of the full 20 points.
- **Op-Ed.** No change in the task; the op-ed does not require AI. You declare that you did not work with AI, with the same Pangram check.
- **Chairing.** You design your session, its graphic materials, and its exercises without AI; the same creativity criterion applies, and the AI-disclosure expectation simply does not arise.
- **In-class.** You complete the AI-free checkpoints and the in-class lab analyses as everyone does; in AI demonstrations you take the analyst-critic role, analysing the demonstration without running the tool yourself.

11 Grading & Appeals

Claude grades the AI Process Logs and checks whether cited sources exist. Dina checks Claude's grading against her own: she re-grades a random sample of the logs herself and compares the two sets of scores. You may ask Dina for the details of this protocol.

Appeal to Dina

If you disagree with Dina's or Claude's grade, you may appeal to Dina **within 7 days**. She re-grades against the same rubric and may adjust the grade up or down. Her decision is final at the course level.

Appeal to the Grade Moderation Committee

If, after speaking with Dina, you still believe your work was graded unfairly or inconsistently with the rubric, you may submit a formal grade appeal to the PSIR Grade Moderation Committee **within 2 weeks** of receiving the grade, with your reasoning.

HOW TO INITIATE A GRADE APPEAL

Email **psir@nu.edu.kz** with subject line **"Grade Appeal"**, including your name, course, the assignment in question, and a brief explanation of your concern. Appeals are reviewed for consistency with the grading criteria and fairness, not for minor point adjustments. The committee may consult Dina and, if necessary, arrange an independent review. The outcome may leave the grade the same, increase it, or (in rare cases) decrease it.

Grading scale

A	A−	B+	B	B−	C+	C	C−	D	D−	F
95–100	90–94	85–89	80–84	75–79	70–74	65–69	60–64	55–59	50–54	0–49

12 Weekly Schedule & Readings

FOUNDATIONS AND THE AI QUESTION · WEEKS 1–2

W1 AUG 19 Introduction to Course and AI Co-Working

How this course works and how we work with AI in it. We go through the course mechanics (the Course Hub, Moodle, the Analysis Portfolios, the op-ed, and chairing) and the AI co-working setup: the two rules, the labs' with-and-without-AI rhythm, and what a cognitive partnership with AI means in practice. **Your task this week:** study this syllabus and the Guide to AI posted on the Course Hub, and bring your questions. **Chair sign-up closes before this session** (form on the Course Hub).

READINGS

- Syllabus and *A Field Guide to a Phenomenon in Motion*.

W2 AUG 26 What Is Qualitative Research? The Divide and AI's Emerging Role

CHAIRSHIP · 3 CHAIRS

What is qualitative research, and what kinds of knowledge does it produce? We put one axis on the board: explanation versus understanding. We also separate two divides that are often confused: qualitative versus quantitative, and positivist versus interpretivist. Rubin defines the field. Hammersley maps the positivist–interpretivist divide itself. Mahoney and Goertz chart the qualitative–quantitative one. Chatzichristos asks whether AI is pushing qualitative research back toward positivism.

REQUIRED

- Rubin (2021), Ch. 1–2.
- Hammersley, M. (2013). *What Is Qualitative Research?* Bloomsbury Academic, Ch. 2 ("Methodological philosophies," pp. 21–45). DOI: 10.5040/9781849666084
- Mahoney, J. & Goertz, G. (2006). A tale of two cultures: Contrasting quantitative and qualitative research. *Political Analysis, 14*(3), 227–249.
- Chatzichristos, G. (2025). Qualitative research in the era of AI: A return to positivism or a new paradigm? *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24.* DOI: 10.1177/16094069251337583

RECOMMENDED

- Schroeder, H., Aubin Le Quéré, M., Randazzo, C., Mimno, D. & Schoenebeck, S. (2025). Large language models in qualitative research: Uses, tensions, and intentions. *CHI '25.* DOI: 10.1145/3706598.3713120
- Seyler, A. et al. (2025). How does generative AI compare to human analysts in qualitative research? A systematic review of large language models. *OSF Preprints.* DOI: 10.31234/osf.io/gnx8p
- Fischer, F. (2025). Interpretivism vs. positivism in policy studies: Is there common ground? *Critical Policy Studies, 19*(3), 371–376. DOI: 10.1080/19460171.2025.2536645

POSITIVIST (EXPLANATORY) QUAL · WEEKS 3–4

W3 SEP 2 Case Studies and Case Selection

CHAIRSHIP · 2 CHAIRS

What case studies do, and how to pick a case. Rubin covers research design and case selection in plain terms. Green et al. open the causal-inference topic accessibly. Levy gives the types of case studies and what each is for. Seawright and Gerring give the menu of case-selection techniques.

REQUIRED

- Rubin (2021), Ch. 5–6 (research design and case selection).
- Green, J., Hanckel, B., Petticrew, M., Paparini, S. & Shaw, S. (2022). Case study research and causal inference. *BMC Medical Research Methodology, 22,* 307. DOI: 10.1186/s12874-022-01790-8
- Levy, J. S. (2008). Case studies: Types, designs, and logics of inference. *Conflict Management and Peace Science, 25*(1), 1–18.
- Seawright, J. & Gerring, J. (2008). Case selection techniques in case study research. *Political Research Quarterly, 61*(2), 294–308.

W4 SEP 9 Process Tracing

LAB

AI-FREE CHECKPOINT

The first lab, and the explanatory tradition hands-on. **First half:** I introduce process tracing with Beach and Pedersen: what a causal mechanism is, what counts as a trace of one, and how to judge what a piece of evidence can prove. The two questions we will use all session: if an explanation is true, would this evidence have to be there? And could it be there anyway, even if the explanation is false? **Second half:** you work through a short synthetic case file **by hand, without AI**: find the evidence in it, build the rival explanations worth testing, weigh each piece of evidence against them, and share your analysis. **At home:** give your AI the same file to process-trace on its own, question it about its reasoning, and write up **Analysis Portfolio #1 (due Fri Sep 18, 11 pm)**. There is no "AI does process tracing" literature yet, so your portfolio is a small first test. Beach and Pedersen's two chapters are your primer: read them before class. The checkpoint is a short without-AI task opening the session, before the process-tracing lab itself.

REQUIRED

- Beach, D. & Pedersen, R. B. (2019). *Process-Tracing Methods: Foundations and Guidelines* (2nd ed.). University of Michigan Press. Ch. 1 ("What Is Process-Tracing?"): read pp. 1–12 closely, skim the rest. Ch. 5 ("Making Inferences Using Mechanistic Evidence"): read pp. 155–158 and 171–193 closely, skim the in-between critique of older approaches; where the Bayesian notation gets thick, hold on to the plain-language definitions and the worked example.

RECOMMENDED

- Collier, D. (2011). Understanding process tracing. *PS: Political Science & Politics, 44*(4), 823–830.
- Bennett, A. & Checkel, J. T. (2015). Process tracing: From philosophical roots to best practices. In *Process Tracing: From Metaphor to Analytic Tool* (pp. 3–37). Cambridge University Press.
- Sanaei, A. & Rajabzadeh, A. (2025). Depth and autonomy: A framework for evaluating LLM applications in social science research. *arXiv: 2510.25432.*

◆ **Analysis Portfolio #1 due Fri Sep 18, 11 pm**

DATA ETHICS WITH AI · WEEK 5

W5 SEP 16 Data Ethics, Transparency, and the Oracle Effect

CHAIRSHIP · 2 CHAIRS

With your first AI lab pass behind you, we settle the ethics properly: consent, anonymisation, and when AI analysis of qualitative data is legitimate. We also meet the "oracle effect": trusting fluent AI output instead of checking it. Zook et al. give ten rules for responsible data research. Kapiszewski and Karcher show what transparency looks like in practice. Nguyen and Welch name the oracle effect.

REQUIRED

- Zook, M. et al. (2017). Ten simple rules for responsible big data research. *PLOS Computational Biology, 13*(3).
- Kapiszewski, D. & Karcher, S. (2021). Transparency in practice in qualitative research. *PS: Political Science & Politics, 54*(2), 285–291.
- Nguyen, D. C. & Welch, C. (2026). Generative artificial intelligence in qualitative data analysis: Analyzing—or just chatting? *Organizational Research Methods, 29*(1), 3–39. DOI: 10.1177/10944281251377154

INTERPRETIVIST QUAL: FOUNDATIONS, LABS, AND THE REFLEXIVITY / RTA ARC · WEEKS 6–12

W6 SEP 23 Interpretivism, Ethnography, and the Interview

CHAIRSHIP · 3 CHAIRS

The interpretivist turn: meaning, situated knowledge, and the interview as a relationship rather than an extraction. Pachirat shows what an immersed, embodied researcher does that a model cannot stand in for. Rubin covers fieldwork-style data collection, including interviewing. Fujii shows that silences, rumours, and evasions are data too. Reflexivity is introduced lightly here and taken up in depth in Weeks 9–12.

REQUIRED

- Pachirat, T. (2018). *Among Wolves: Ethnography and the Immersive Study of Power.* Routledge, Act 1.
- Rubin (2021), Ch. 8 (the fieldwork model of data collection, including interviewing).
- Fujii, L. A. (2010). Shades of truth and lies: Interpreting testimonies of war and violence. *Journal of Peace Research, 47*(2), 231–241.

RECOMMENDED

- Pachirat (2018), Acts 2–3.
- Schwartz-Shea, P. & Yanow, D. (2012). *Interpretive Research Design.* Routledge, Ch. 1–2.

W7 SEP 30 Grounded Theory

CHAIRSHIP · 2 CHAIRS

AI-FREE CHECKPOINT

Grounded theory straddles explanation and understanding, and this week is its theory. Where the method came from (Glaser and Strauss), how it evolved (Strauss and Corbin's procedures, Charmaz's constructivist turn), and its working parts: coding stages, constant comparison, theoretical sampling, memo-writing, saturation. Chun Tie et al. is the primer. Kenny and Fourie map the three versions of the method and how they disagree. Charmaz shows what the constructivist version is for. Next week you put all of it on the coding table.

REQUIRED

- Chun Tie, Y., Birks, M. & Francis, K. (2019). Grounded theory research: A design framework for novice researchers. *SAGE Open Medicine, 7.* DOI: 10.1177/2050312118822927
- Kenny, M. & Fourie, R. (2015). Contrasting classic, Straussian, and constructivist grounded theory: Methodological and philosophical conflicts. *The Qualitative Report, 20*(8), 1270–1289. DOI: 10.46743/2160-3715/2015.2251
- Charmaz, K. (2017). The power of constructivist grounded theory for critical inquiry. *Qualitative Inquiry, 23*(1), 34–45.

RECOMMENDED

- Mills, J., Bonner, A. & Francis, K. (2006). The development of constructivist grounded theory. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 5*(1), 25–35. DOI: 10.1177/160940690600500103
- Nelson, L. K. (2020). Computational grounded theory: A methodological framework. *Sociological Methods & Research, 49*(1), 3–42.

Break OCT 5–9 Fall Break

No class. A good week to rest; the grounded theory lab is waiting when you return.

W8 OCT 14 Grounded Theory

LAB

The second lab. **First half:** I take last week's theory to the coding table: what line-by-line open coding looks like in practice, how categories grow out of codes, and what separates good grounded theory coding from bad, using Charmaz and Thornberg's quality criteria and their worked example. **Second half:** you open-code a short synthetic interview dataset **by hand, without AI**, and hand your coding in. **At home:** develop your categories by hand following Yue et al.'s procedure, then run the same data through your AI with the same prompts (their Steps 1–3), question it about its decisions, and write up **Analysis Portfolio #2 (due Fri Oct 23, 11 pm)**.

REQUIRED

- Charmaz, K. & Thornberg, R. (2021). The pursuit of quality in grounded theory. *Qualitative Research in Psychology, 18*(3), 305–327. DOI: 10.1080/14780887.2020.1780357
- Yue, Y., Liu, D., Lv, Y., Hao, J. & Cui, P. (2025). A practical guide and assessment on using ChatGPT to conduct grounded theory: Tutorial. *JMIR, 27,* e70122. DOI: 10.2196/70122

◆ **Analysis Portfolio #2 due Fri Oct 23, 11 pm**

RECOMMENDED

- Costa, A. P., Bryda, G., Christou, P. A. & Kasperiuniene, J. (2025). AI as a co-researcher in the qualitative research workflow. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24.* DOI: 10.1177/16094069251383739

W9 OCT 21 Reflexivity and AI

CHAIRSHIP · 3 CHAIRS

AI-FREE CHECKPOINT

What reflexivity *is* and what it *requires*, before we ask whether AI can do it. Mauthner and Doucet locate reflexivity at the analysis stage, exactly where the AI question lives. Haraway supplies the idea the whole debate runs on: all knowledge comes from somewhere, and a knower who claims to stand nowhere is performing a trick. Messner et al. bring that vocabulary to AI directly. Savolainen et al. (recommended) is the contrarian voice: maybe human reflexivity statements do not deliver what they claim either.

REQUIRED

- Mauthner, N. S. & Doucet, A. (2003). Reflexive accounts and accounts of reflexivity in qualitative data analysis. *Sociology, 37*(3), 413–431.
- Haraway, D. (1988). Situated knowledges: The science question in feminism and the privilege of partial perspective. *Feminist Studies, 14*(3), 575–599.
- Messner, R., Smith, S. & Richards, C. (2025). Artificial intelligence and qualitative data analysis: Epistemological incongruences. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24.* DOI: 10.1177/16094069251371481

RECOMMENDED

- Finlay, L. (2002). Negotiating the swamp: The opportunity and challenge of reflexivity in research practice. *Qualitative Research, 2*(2), 209–230.
- Savolainen, J., Casey, P. J., McBrayer, J. P. & Schwerdtle, P. N. (2023). Positionality and its problems: Questioning the value of reflexivity statements in research. *Perspectives on Psychological Science, 18*(6), 1331–1338.

W10 OCT 28 Reflexive Thematic Analysis

LAB

The third lab. **First half:** I introduce reflexive thematic analysis: Braun and Clarke's three families of TA (coding-reliability, codebook, reflexive), why agreement numbers say nothing about reflexive TA, and what a theme is (a pattern of shared meaning, not a topic bucket). **Second half:** phases 1–3 (familiarise, code, draft candidate themes) **by hand, without AI**, on a short synthetic dataset; hand your analysis in. **At home:** run the AI pass on the same data, keep an audit trail of every prompt (lab handout), question the model about its theme decisions, and ask it whether it has a positionality of its own. **Analysis Portfolio #3 due Fri Nov 6, 11 pm.** The three Braun and Clarke papers are the method's foundation; the 2021 paper doubles as the portfolio touchstone.

REQUIRED

- Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology, 3*(2), 77–101.
- Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health, 11*(4), 589–597. DOI: 10.1080/2159676X.2019.1628806
- Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2021). One size fits all? What counts as quality practice in (reflexive) thematic analysis? *Qualitative Research in Psychology, 18*(3), 328–352. DOI: 10.1080/14780887.2020.1769238

◆ **Analysis Portfolio #3 due Fri Nov 6, 11 pm**

W11 NOV 4 The RTA Debate: Can Reflexive Research Incorporate AI?

CHAIRSHIP · 3 CHAIRS · STRUCTURED DEBATE

The live controversy: can reflexive qualitative research responsibly incorporate AI? Note what the question is not: nobody in this literature claims AI can *be* reflexive. Jowsey et al. is the rejection letter, 419 signatories, Braun and Clarke among them. Nguyen and Welch supply the sceptics' evidence and the week's sharpest tool: the line between analysing and chatting. Friese et al. argue for a middle path. This is a three-chair week built as a structured debate: one chair frames the controversy, two lead the opposing sides, and you arrive having just done RTA with and without AI yourself.

REQUIRED

- Jowsey, T., Braun, V., Clarke, V., Lupton, D. & Fine, M. (2025). We reject the use of generative artificial intelligence for reflexive qualitative research. *Qualitative Inquiry* (online first). DOI: 10.1177/10778004251401851
- Nguyen, D. C. & Welch, C. (2026). Generative artificial intelligence in qualitative data analysis: Analyzing—or just chatting? *Organizational Research Methods, 29*(1), 3–39.
- Friese, S., Nguyen-Trung, K., Powell, S. & Morgan, D. L. (2026). Beyond binary positions: Making space for critical and reflexive GenAI integration in qualitative research. *Qualitative Inquiry* (online first). DOI: 10.1177/10778004261429393

RECOMMENDED

- Greenhalgh, T. (2026). Reflexive qualitative research and generative AI: A call to go beyond the binary. *Qualitative Inquiry* (online first). DOI: 10.1177/10778004261429383
- Nguyen-Trung, K. (2025). Documenting debates on GenAI in (reflexive) qualitative research. *SSRN 5750283.*

DINA'S POSITION — A STANCE TO ARGUE, NOT SETTLED DOCTRINE

My own position is that the "We Reject" letter rests on an unearned confidence about what humans can do and what AI cannot do, and that line may be thinner than it looks: human reflexivity is itself a practice, something we do and can do badly, not a clear window onto the self. So when an AI names its own trained partiality, is that a different kind of reflexivity? Genuinely open. You do not have to agree with me on any of this. You do have to argue your own position.

W12 NOV 11 AI and Thematic Analysis in Practice: the Literature on Trial

CHAIRSHIP · 2 CHAIRS

You have now done RTA with and without AI; this week the "AI does thematic analysis" literature goes on trial against your own experience. Xu shows how to do TA with AI while keeping reflexivity. Naeem et al. give the most complete step-by-step AI protocol in print, and we read it critically: is each step interpretation, or topic-sorting? The standing question: where does your Portfolio #3 experience confirm these papers, and where does it contradict them?

REQUIRED

- Xu, W. (2026). Doing thematic analysis in the age of generative AI: Practices, ethics and reflexivity. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 25.* DOI: 10.1177/16094069261425173
- Naeem, M., Smith, T. & Thomas, L. (2025). Thematic analysis and artificial intelligence: A step-by-step process for using ChatGPT in thematic analysis. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24.* DOI: 10.1177/16094069251333886

RECOMMENDED

- Qiao, S. et al. (2025). Generative AI for thematic analysis in a maternal health study. *Applied Psychology: Health and Well-Being, 17*(3), e70038. DOI: 10.1111/aphw.70038
- Nyaaba, M. et al. (2025). Optimizing generative AI's accuracy and transparency in inductive thematic analysis. *arXiv:2503.16485.*

SYNTHESIS AND WRAP · WEEKS 13–14

W13 NOV 18 When AI Helps and When We Ask the Wrong Thing of It

CHAIRSHIP · 3 CHAIRS

AI-FREE CHECKPOINT

Tie the course together: whether AI helps depends on what we ask of it, on the research strategy, and on the layer of the work. Bail makes the optimist's case for AI in social science. Nguyen and Welch return for a final read. Ernst and Treude (recommended; their task-sorting is presented in class) sort AI tasks into what it does well and what it should not be asked to do. Revisit over-reliance and where each method placed it.

REQUIRED

- Bail, C. (2024). Can generative AI improve social science? *PNAS.*
- Nguyen & Welch (2026), reprise (see Week 11).

RECOMMENDED

- Ernst, N. A. & Treude, C. (2026). GenAI is no silver bullet for qualitative research in software engineering. *arXiv:2603.08951.*

W14 NOV 25 Defending Qualitative Work and Course Wrap

CHAIRSHIP · 2 CHAIRS

What does everything add up to, and how do you defend it when someone pushes back? Rubin's closing chapters are a field guide to exactly that, and this session splits into a reading half and an activity half.

REQUIRED

- Rubin (2021), Ch. 11–12 ("Living on the Sharp End: Dealing with Skeptics of Qualitative Research" and "The Sweeper").

◆ **Op-Ed due Mon Nov 30, 11 pm, via the Op-Ed Dashboard**